Gmail

Nicholas DiBella <dibellatron@gmail.com>

Fwd: [Response Overdue] Tools Competition Midway Survey

7 messages

Simon Cullen <sc@simoncullen.org> Mon, Feb 16, 2026 at 11:26 AM
To: Nicholas DiBella <nick@swaybeta.ai>, Rachel Sipser <rachel@swaybeta.ai>

---------- Forwarded message ---------
From: **Ben Price** <ben@the-learning-agency.com>
Date: Mon, Feb 16, 2026 at 1:17 PM
Subject: [Response Overdue] Tools Competition Midway Survey
To: <sc@simoncullen.org>
Cc: <ToolsCompetition@the-learning-agency.com>

Hi Simon,

I'm following up about the Tools Impact Evaluation midway survey, as we haven't yet received your responses, which were requested by February 13.

Would you be able to submit your responses here by EOD February 19th? This will help ensure we have comprehensive data across all winners.

Thank you!

Best,
Ben Price Program Associate

--
Ben Price
Program Associate

THE LEARNING AGENCY

Simon Cullen <sc@simoncullen.org> Mon, Feb 16, 2026 at 11:27 AM
To: Ben Price <ben@the-learning-agency.com>
Cc: Nicholas DiBella <nick@swaybeta.ai>, SwayBeta Team <support@swaybeta.ai>

Dear Ben,

Apologies for the delay and thanks for your patience—I've been traveling nonstop and just got back to NYC on Sat. I will do my best to have this in for you by Weds, but if we need the additional time, would Friday EOD work for you?

Warmly,
Simon
[Quoted text hidden]

Ben Price <ben@the-learning-agency.com> Mon, Feb 16, 2026 at 11:29 AM
To: Simon Cullen <sc@simoncullen.org>
Cc: Nicholas DiBella <nick@swaybeta.ai>, SwayBeta Team <support@swaybeta.ai>

Hi Simon,

Thanks for your email. That will be fine—we appreciate your work on this!

Best,
Ben
[Quoted text hidden]

Simon Cullen <sc@simoncullen.org> Mon, Feb 16, 2026 at 11:29 AM
To: Ben Price <ben@the-learning-agency.com>
Cc: Nicholas DiBella <nick@swaybeta.ai>, SwayBeta Team <support@swaybeta.ai>

🙏

Simon Cullen reacted via Gmail
[Quoted text hidden]

Simon Cullen <sc@simoncullen.org> Fri, Feb 20, 2026 at 10:26 PM
To: Ben Price <ben@the-learning-agency.com>
Cc: Nicholas DiBella <nick@swaybeta.ai>, SwayBeta Team <support@swaybeta.ai>

Hi Ben,

I hope this finds you well. I wanted to update you on Sway and see if you have time for a quick call in the next week or so.

The big headline: Sway has grown significantly since our proposal. We're now in use at 80+ colleges and universities with over 8,500 students, up from around 30 institutions and 2,000 students when we applied. It's been a really exciting (and demanding) year of scaling.

On the deliverables front: our proposal had two main features. The first, Instructor Insights (analytics giving instructors visibility into how their students engaged with discussion topics), is complete-- we're generating comprehensive automated reports for instructors after every assignment. The second, ChatMaps (AI-powered visualization of how student arguments evolve during a conversation), has been delayed. The growth in adoption consumed most of our development bandwidth because scaling came with challenges we didn't foresee, and working through those pushed back our timeline for new features.

One upside of the delay: we now have a massive dataset of real student discussions across 80+ institutions and a wide range of disciplines. That data is invaluable for building and testing ChatMaps. The argument-mapping features will be far stronger for having tens of thousands of real student arguments to develop against rather than a small pilot set.

I also want to flag an organizational update. The nonprofit that submitted our proposal, Disagree Wisely, is formalizing as a 501(c)(3) focused on research and education. As part of that process, we're separating software development into a different entity. In light of this, we would like to discuss the best way to proceed.

We've also just submitted the midway survey. I apologize for the delay on that. You'll see in our responses that we touch on some of these organizational questions. But I think a call would be the easiest way to walk through the details and figure out the right approach together. Are you free for 20–30 minutes sometime next week?

Thanks, Ben! We're looking forward to catching up soon.

Best,
Simon (& Nick)
[Quoted text hidden]

Kristyn Manoukian <kristyn@the-learning-agency.com> Mon, Feb 23, 2026 at 10:46 AM
To: sc@simoncullen.org
Cc: nick@swaybeta.ai, support@swaybeta.ai, Ben Price <ben@the-learning-agency.com>

Hi Simon,

Hope you're well. Ben forwarded your note. I'm happy to connect by phone and hear more about these updates. I dropped a few times below my signature.

Best,
Kristyn

Eastern Time - New York (GMT-05:00)

Mon, March 2

10:00 – 10:30 AM | 11:30 AM – 12:00 PM | 2:00 – 2:30 PM | 2:30 – 3:00 PM

Tue, March 3

12:00 – 12:30 PM | 1:30 – 2:00 PM

Wed, March 4

9:00 – 9:30 AM | 12:30 – 1:00 PM

View in Calendar

On Mon, Feb 23, 2026 at 10:59 AM Ben Price <ben@the-learning-agency.com> wrote:
[Quoted text hidden]

Simon Cullen <support@swaybeta.ai> Mon, Mar 2, 2026 at 2:56 PM
To: Kristyn Manoukian <kristyn@the-learning-agency.com>
Cc: nick@swaybeta.ai, support@swaybeta.ai, Ben Price <ben@the-learning-agency.com>

Hi Kristyn,

Thank you so much for meeting with us today — we really appreciated it. As promised, here's a written recap. I've tried to make this self-contained in case it's useful to forward to your finance team or Digital Harbor.

1. Growth & Deliverables

Sway has taken off at a much greater pace than we expected: we now have instructors at over 80 campuses reaching nearly 10,000 students, up from about 30 institutions and 2,000 students at proposal time. Obviously this is a great problem to have, but it's definitely stretching our small team.

The first deliverable in our proposal, Instructor Insights, is complete and serves instructors really well. The platform automatically generates comprehensive reports at the end of every assignment. We've had amazing feedback from instructors (check out the example reports here).

The second deliverable, ChatMaps, has been delayed. We've begun preliminary research but haven't started full development. As we said, the edge cases that emerge at each new level of scale required a lot of engineering effort, which is what slowed us down.

2. How Our Plan Has Evolved

Two things have changed since our proposal:

- Our considerable growth has consumed nearly all our development bandwidth. We prioritized keeping the platform reliable for existing users and building much-needed features surfaced by instructors. This has pushed back the ChatMaps timeline.
- AI capabilities have advanced significantly. AI coding tools are getting better and cheaper, so it's quite plausible we can build ChatMaps for meaningfully less than we initially estimated.

As we discussed, greater flexibility in how our remaining Tools funds are used would be *immensely* helpful for us. If we can allocate some Tools funds to operational and scaling costs that our growth has created, that wouldn't stop us from building ChatMaps; rather, it would just mean we'd either build it more cheaply or supplement with other funding. The $4M DOE/FIPSE grant we recently won as part of the ICDC consortium explicitly supports ChatMaps development, so the feature has multiple paths to completion. (Note, however, that the ICDC funding may not be available to us until next year.)

3. Organizational Update & the Remaining Funds

When we applied to the Tools Competition, we were founding a nonprofit called Disagree Wisely, which we expected would be a home for our research, education work, *and* software development. It turns out that our efforts to formalize as a 501(c)(3) made it clear we needed to separate out the software development from the nonprofit.

We now sit with approximately $125,000 of Tools funding in Disagree Wisely's bank account that can no longer be compliantly spent on development. We'd like to return those funds to Digital Harbor so they can be redirected to a for-profit entity we're in the process of establishing. We understand this may involve coordinating with Digital Harbor Foundation and are happy to work with whatever process makes sense.

4. Highlights & Links

You mentioned you'd love some highlights to share with the Axim Collaborative and Calbright partners. Here are the big ones:

- Chronicle of Higher Education
- $4M DOE/FIPSE Grant (ICDC initiative)
- Additional Sway press coverage
- Platform-wide student results
- Student chat showcase
- Instructor report showcase

We'd love to have you explore the site when you're feeling better — the student conversation showcase is something we're especially proud of :)

Thank you again, Kristyn. The Tools Competition has been an amazing asset for us-- not just the funding itself, but as I mentioned, the credibility. We rely on it all the time when pitching to donors and writing grants. It has been a true badge of honor!

We'd love to stay in closer touch, and we hope you feel better soon.

Warmly,

Simon (& Nick)

[Quoted text hidden]

SwayBeta.ai
Simon Cullen, Ph.D
Sway Co-creator

Co-Founder & President I Disagree Wisely

Faculty Research Fellow | Heterodox Academy

Visiting Research Professor of Civil Discourse & AI |

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